

The Compleat Economic Voter in Belgium: Channels of Accountability in a Complex Multilevel Government System

Martin Okolikj, University of Bergen

Marc Hooghe, University of Leuven

Michael S. Lewis-Beck, University of Iowa

Recent literature has suggested that economic voting is a multidimensional concept, where valence is but one aspect of the compleat economic voter, along with economic policy position and patrimony (i.e., ownership of assets). Leveraging data from the 2019 Belgian election survey within a distinctive electoral context, this study makes two significant contributions: Firstly, it demonstrates multidimensional economic voting exists in a complex electoral setting, such as that of Belgium. Secondly, it reveals that regional economic development engenders conditional diverse dimensions of the compleat economic voter. In Flanders, a region that incentivizes liberal market competition, we find the emergence of high-risk patrimonial voters. In contrast, Wallonia, a region with strong industry protectionism, encourages valence and positional economics dimensions. These findings have implications for both the economic voting and the multilevel governance literatures.

Studies of economic voting suggest that when the economy does well, incumbent governments are more likely to remain in office. Further, when citizens perceive the economy to be in decline, support for incumbents also declines (Lewis-Beck and Stegmaier 2000). This traditional reward–punishment hypothesis has received robust recognition in the literature (Dassonneville and Lewis-Beck 2019; Duch and Stevenson 2008; Lewis-Beck 1990; Stegmaier, Lewis-Beck, and Park 2017), albeit there are those with critical views toward this approach (Anderson 2007; Evans and Andersen 2006; Evans and Pickup 2010; van der Brug, van der Eijk, and Franklin 2007). These critics contend that economic perceptions are biased by partisanship, making economic evaluation endogenous to party preferences (i.e., partisanship “colors” evaluations of the economy; Evans and

Andersen 2006; van der Brug et al. 2007). In response to the issue of endogeneity, more recent literature has argued that economic voting is multidimensional, with valence being just one aspect of the compleat economic voter, alongside voter positions on economic policy and their patrimonial possessions (Lewis-Beck and Nadeau 2011; Lewis-Beck, Nadeau, and Foucault 2013; Nadeau, Foucault, and Lewis-Beck 2010). In this article, we test multidimensionality of economic voting but also extend the scope of the compleat economic voter in multilevel settings, using the 2019 Belgian federal and regional elections.

Belgium is a complicated federal system, presenting challenges for citizens when accrediting accountability for policy outcomes, especially as clarity of responsibility is low (Dassonneville, Hooghe, and Debus 2017; Powell and Whitten 1993). Second,

Martin Okolikj (martin.okolic@gmail.com) is a postdoctoral research fellow at the Department of Comparative Politics, University of Bergen, 5007 Bergen, Norway, and a visiting researcher at the Institute for Social Research, 0260 Oslo, Norway. Marc Hooghe (marc.hooghe@kuleuven.be) is a full professor of political science at the University of Leuven, 3000 Leuven, Belgium, and a visiting professor at the Universities of Mannheim, Lille-II and Utrecht. Michael S. Lewis-Beck (michael-lewis-beck@uiowa.edu) is F. Wendell Miller Distinguished Professor of Political Science at the University of Iowa, Iowa City, IA 52242.

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there are two different political regions (i.e., Flanders and Wallonia) with sophisticated and distinct party dynamics, which further complicates citizens' ability to evaluate party performance. Third, Belgium's multilevel governance structure adds an additional layer of difficulty for voters trying to gauge responsibility for policy outcomes. This high level of complexity makes Belgium a particularly demanding test of the compleat economic voter thesis.

Our study has two aims. First, we test the multidimensional economic voting model in the complex Belgian case. Second, within the specific context of the 2019 Belgian elections, we study the development of the multidimensional economic voter in different historical and economic circumstances. More specifically, the unique case of Belgium allows us to compare within-country regional economic development, which could be considered a precondition for certain dimensions of economic voting, as compared to others. For example, the regional economic development in Flanders, a product of private business and a service-oriented economy, we believe facilitates private ownership, necessary for high-risk patrimonial voters. In contrast, Wallonia's regional economic development, predominantly based on heavy industry and a strong social labor movement, resulted in valence and positional economics dominating the multidimensional economic voter. Since the two-level elections in our study were held simultaneously (i.e., federal and regional), this means that current economic circumstances in the two regions are held constant. Further, the uniqueness of the 2019 elections in Belgium, where the incumbency status is predominantly center-right, allows a rare occasion for multidimensional economic voting to be tested.

Our article proceeds as follows. First, we review the literature on the multidimensional economic voter. Second, we provide detailed information about the political, economic, and historical circumstances in Belgium, before and during the 2019 elections. Third, we present the data gathered in a postelection survey, focusing on the two electoral contests held in May 2019. Fourth, we unfold the analytical framework and the results. The final section is dedicated to summary and discussion.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Since its theoretical foundations in the early 1960s, economic voting has been a driving force in the investigation of democratic accountability (Butler and Stokes 1974; Campbell et al. 1960; Downs 1957; Key 1966; Kramer 1971). As Tufte (1978, 65) observed, "when you think economics, think elections; when you think elections, think economics." That is, economic performance has offered a ready way to gauge in-

cumbents' governing success or failure (Duch and Stevenson 2008).

However, this straightforward concept has not gone unchallenged. In particular, some scholars have cast doubts on the independent effects of economic perceptions, suggesting an endogenous relation with respondent partisan affiliations. According to these authors, citizens supporting the incumbent government would see the economy in a more positive manner, regardless of the real economic situation (Anderson 2007; Evans and Andersen 2006; Evans and Chzheng 2016; Evans and Pickup 2010; van der Brug et al. 2007). Nevertheless, the claims about endogeneity have been countered (Lewis-Beck and Nadeau 2011; Whiteley et al. 2016), with evidence that while partisans might be more forgiving of their party, they still manage to hold realistic views of the economy and to vote accordingly (De Vries, Hobolt, and Tilley 2018; Okolikj and Hooghe 2020). Relatedly, the unidimensional flow of endogeneity has been questioned because the aggregate economy appears able to shape partisanship, with incumbents gaining partisans in good economic times and losing partisans in bad economic times (Okolikj, Quinlan, and Lewis-Beck 2022).

Related to the debate about endogeneity, Lewis-Beck and Nadeau (2011) pointed out that valence offers very little information about the economic position of voters (i.e., citizens' specific stance along a range of choices about a particular economic issue). In other words, valence reflects consensus, with all voters obviously in favor of more economic prosperity. Nevertheless, this prosperity might be achieved through taking different policy positions on the economy (Nezi and Katsanidou 2014). Evidence of this positional economic voting has been found in various settings, including the United States (Lewis-Beck and Nadeau 2011), the United Kingdom (Lewis-Beck et al. 2013), Germany (Okolikj and Quinlan 2021), Spain (Fraile and Lewis-Beck 2013), and Greece (Nezi and Katsanidou 2014), as well as comparatively (Quinlan and Okolikj 2020). These studies underline an increasing interest in the positional dimension of the economic voter. Further, the effects of positional economic voting have been found to be more pronounced in times of economic hardship, when there is little variation in the valence model, such as in the 2012 parliamentary elections in Greece (Nezi and Katsanidou 2014), or cross-nationally following the economic crisis (Talving 2017).

Positional economics literature relies, in particular, on citizens' views regarding income redistribution, a highly recognizable economic policy distinction,¹ with those favoring

1. For a wider set of positional measures, see Quinlan and Okolikj (2020) and van der Brug et al. (2007).

more income redistribution reporting a vote for the Left, and those against it favoring a vote for the Right. Such a pattern was observed in the 2008 Spanish elections where those hesitant about higher taxation were less likely to vote for the Spanish Socialist Party, Partido Socialista Obrero Español (Fraile and Lewis-Beck 2013). Similarly, among those whose economic views favored a self-regulated market, they reported a greater likelihood of voting for the center-right coalition of the Christian Democratic Union/Christian Social Union and Free Democratic Party in the 2013 German Federal Election (Okolikj and Quinlan 2021). In the 2019 elections in Belgium, the socialist, radical left, and green parties stressed the fight against inequality, while the center or right-wing parties argued that high tax rates would jeopardize economic growth.

A third dimension of the economic voter concerns the assets, or wealth, the citizens hold (i.e., patrimony). Following patrimonial expectations, voters are not just observers of the economy; they also hold positions based on their personal location in the economic stratification structure. Simply put, what one owns indicates for whom they will vote, in an effort to protect their wealth (Lewis-Beck and Nadeau 2011). Thus, increased patrimony makes voters more egotropic and more strategic in protecting their assets.

There has been an increasing number of case studies examining patrimonial voting. For example, patrimonial voting has been shown to have a direct effect on vote choice in Australia, Britain, Denmark, Germany, Sweden, and the United States, including comparatively (Hellwig and McAllister 2019; Quinlan and Okolikj 2022). Quinlan and Okolikj (2022), for example, find that patrimony is more pronounced in countries with liberal welfare systems, and in countries where the tax system promotes incentives for investments. The greater the number of assets, the higher the probability of vote for parties that are against high taxes, usually meaning those parties are on the right of the economic ideology scale.

The patrimony literature is not unified on how one measures assets. Various types of assets have been investigated, including home ownership, savings, business ownership, and stocks and bonds. However, studies suggest that a more nuanced approach is needed, where patrimony should be divided by type of assets (i.e., low-risk assets and high-risk assets; Hellwig and McAllister 2018; Persson and Martinsson 2018; Stubager, Lewis-Beck, and Nadeau 2013). This differentiation is crucial because each type of asset reflects a unique investment personality based on different party policy proposals (Hellwig and McAllister 2018). For example, people holding high-risk assets (i.e., stocks and bonds, business ownership) face increased financial volatility and consequently would be more attentive to how elections could impact their personal wealth. Consequently, they may be inclined to support parties

that advocate for market competition and reduce state intervention. On the other hand, individuals who own low-risk assets (home ownership and savings) bear few direct political repercussions on their holdings and tend to prioritize stability over time, making them more risk-averse. In this study, we adopt Persson and Martinsson's (2018) categorization of patrimony, distinguishing between high-risk assets (a business, property, farm, or livestock ownership and stocks or bonds ownership) and low-risk assets (house ownership and savings). This differentiation is essential because different motivations link patrimony to voting choices.

These three dimensions of the economic vote—valence, positional economics, and patrimony—form the multidimensional or compleat economic voter, an elector increasingly studied, as this literature review makes clear. However, we are the first to test this concept in a complex regionally diverse political setting such as Belgium, where clarity of responsibility is convoluted. Below, we focus on our hypotheses with respect to the Belgian case, beginning with the first hypothesis.

H1. Multidimensional economic voting predicts vote for incumbent coalition parties in 2019 Belgian federal elections.

More specifically, we expect all three dimensions of economic voting (i.e., valence, positional economics, and patrimony) will be positively associated with a reported vote for the incumbent coalition, a coalition that was composed of predominantly center-right parties on the federal level and likewise at the regional level. Following valence economics, we expect those believing economic conditions have improved over the past year will show higher probability of voting for the incumbent coalition parties (a dimension of economic vote not affected by ideological positioning of political parties). Second, respondents who disagree that government should intervene to reduce income disparities (a positional economics dimension) would be more likely to also support the center-right governing parties. Finally, we expect respondents that report more assets, specifically high-risk assets, will also support the center-right incumbent coalition government.

Belgium: Dimensions of the compleat economic voter at the regional level

Our second major interest concerns the multilevel governance aspect of the compleat economic voter, something not yet tested. The literature on regional elections points to the so-called methodological nationalism bias, where scholars use national elections as the natural unit of analysis, ignoring many regional- and territorial-related heterogeneities (Jeffery and Schakel 2013; Schakel 2013). Especially in the context of

Belgium, where different political party systems compete in different regions and where the historical development of economic interests varies across the regions, the recognition of differentiated multilevel statehood becomes very important. We believe that the regional level of government provides an additional layer of information that might lead us to determine the roots of multidimensionality in economic voting. We have an almost ideal case study for testing this.

Belgium, as a federal country, is composed of four regions: Flanders, Wallonia, Brussels (the capital), and the much smaller region of the German-speaking community. Flanders and Wallonia are the two major regions, representing around 90% of the Belgian population. These regions are marked by deeply divided societies with historical, religious, cultural, linguistic, and notably economic disparities.

Culturally and linguistically, Flanders is closely connected to the Germanic group of languages, linked to and influenced by northern European states (i.e., the Netherlands, Germany, England). While Wallonia, a French-speaking region, bears linguistic and cultural influence from southern European states such as France, Spain, Italy, and Portugal. These distinctions are rooted in different historical factors that have shaped varying economic and political party development trajectories across the regions. As a result, we expect that these different economic and political party developments will lead to distinguished sets of economic voters in Flanders, as compared to Wallonia. For instance, during the early twentieth century, Wallonia was predominantly industrialized, developed by heavy industries such as coal and steel, and was historically dominated by the Socialist Party (PS; former Worker's Party). This political domination of the PS was a product of the strong labor movement in the region. Wallonia's economic policy centered on subsidizing existing enterprises to ensure employment in traditional industries, where investments were unlikely to materialize (Deschouwer 2009, 209). This approach favored state protectionism, with the government playing a central economic role as an employer and main economic power, resulting in higher needs for social assistance (Deschouwer 2009, 203–8). Such economic policies may not align with high-risk patrimonial voters, as they promote protectionism and discourage risk-investment portfolios. The positional economics dimension of economic voting in Wallonia is more likely to lean left, with the state actively taking a role in income distribution in the society.

On the contrary, the historical evolution of the Flemish region was influenced by the Catholic Church, which played a role in maintaining private education and supporting privatization over state-imposed restrictions. An agrarian economy in the early twentieth century facilitated ownership (e.g., farms and business), leading to the development of a business- and

service-oriented economy. Economic policies in Flanders adopted a more liberal approach, focusing on attracting investments through lower taxes, an open-market environment, and incentives for investments, thus differentiating it clearly from the Walloon region. These liberal open-market economic policies increased Flanders' fiscal capacity and provide a solid foundation for the creation of patrimonial high-risk voters, and voters with economic policies that prioritize market regulation over state intervention.

We believe that these divergent historical paths have given rise to different types of multidimensional economic voters within the country. Analyzing the region as a unit of analysis allows us to distinguish these different types of multidimensional economic voters within the country. Belgium's two strong regional tiers of government (Hooghe, Marks, and Schakel 2010), where regional elections are considered of the first order of importance, prompted us to test our hypothesis within both the federal and regional electoral contexts. These considerations generate our second set of hypotheses.

H2a. Valence, patrimony (i.e., high-risk asset ownership), and positional economics will be positively associated with vote for incumbent coalition parties in 2019 federal and regional elections in Flanders.

H2b. Valence and positional economics will be positively associated with vote for incumbent party/coalition parties in 2019 federal and regional elections in Wallonia.

This idea that economic development shapes the characteristics of economic voters builds upon earlier work by Quinlan and Okolikj (2022), who argue that the welfare state and the tax systems in place create different patrimonial voters. Nevertheless, we go a step further using a case in which state-level policies regarding the welfare system and tax structures remain constant but where historical evolution of the economic development (open market or strong labor movement) has led to different types of multidimensional economic voters.

Context of the 2019 elections

Prior to the 2019 federal elections, the incumbent coalition parties from the Flemish region were three political parties, the New Flemish Alliance (N-VA), the Christian Democratic and Flemish Party (CD&V), and the Open Flemish Liberal and Democrats (Open VLD). A governing party from the Walloon region was the Reformist Movement (MR), with Prime Minister Charles Michel coming from MR. However, only five months before the elections in December 2018, the largest Flemish

coalition party N-VA, due to political crisis surrounding the Global Compact for Migration, left the governing coalition, leaving the other three parties in minority government.

On a regional level, the three center-right Flemish parties governed the Flemish region, having a comfortable majority throughout the term. In Wallonia, however, the regional politics were somewhat more complex. The incumbent coalition was composed of MR on the right and a center party Humanist Democratic Centre (cdH). The winning coalition in the previous 2014 regional elections in Walloon broke in 2017 due to several political scandals regarding the larger coalition member, the PS, a leftist party. The cdH then, for the first time in Walloon history, formed a governing coalition with MR, having incumbency status for the next two years, before the elections in May 2019, changing the overall ideological composition of the incumbents in Wallonia to center/center-right. The federal and regional elections in Belgium were held simultaneously on May 26, 2019.

DATA AND ANALYSIS

Our data come from the 2019 Belgian election study, a survey that we collected for the 2019 federal and regional elections in the two main regions of Belgium: Flanders and Wallonia. Using a random sample of respondents drawn from the National Register of voters in Belgium, we administered 8,000 paper questionnaires (4,000 per region) by mail to voters.² The response rate in the Flemish region was 27%, while in Wallonia the response rate was 18%, resulting in a total number of 1,820 completed surveys (for a 22.75% overall response rate across Belgium).

Our study measures two dependent variables, in order to compare the two types of elections in the 2019 contests. First, we measure vote for the incumbent party on the federal level, followed by regional elections. Three parties are considered incumbents on the federal level in Flanders (i.e., the Open VLD, the New N-VA, and the CD&V), while MR is the incumbent on the federal level from Wallonia. For regional elections in Wallonia, besides MR, another incumbent party was the cdH. Our dependent variables are binary following reported vote choice based on the following question: which party did you vote for in the federal/regional (Belgian) elections of May 26, 2019? Those who reported vote for the incumbent parties were coded one and zero otherwise.

We measure economic perceptions using the standard sociotropic question, where respondents were asked to evaluate the economic situation in Belgium in the past 12 months

ranging from 1 “strongly deteriorated” to 5 “strongly improved.” The report from the 2021 Belgian Federal planning bureau on regional economic performance in Flanders and Wallonia suggests that during this period the two regions had very similar economic performance (see fig. 1 in app. 1; Bassilière et al. 2021). Therefore, our measure of the overall economic perceptions is used for both types of elections. We measure positional economics using the standard question on income redistribution, asking the economic position of Belgian voters on a five-point scale using the following statement: “government should take measures to reduce income disparities,” with 1 referring to “strongly agree” and 5 “strongly disagree.” The third economic variable measures patrimony, divided into two categories. First, we measure high-risk asset ownership, which includes ownership of stocks or bonds, and ownership of a business, property, farm, or livestock using an index (i.e., 0–2 items). Second, we measure low-risk asset ownership, such as ownership of a house or an apartment, and savings (by respondent or a family member) using an additive index (i.e., 0–2 items).

We include a large set of political control variables, such as party identification, respondent ideological left–right self-placement, respondents’ interest in politics, and their satisfaction with the federal government, views on immigration, trust in the political system, and Europeanization attitudes. Also, we use several individual-level sociodemographic controls, such as age, gender, marital status, education, employment, and religiosity.

Descriptive analysis

The ideological division of the parties in the Belgian elections was calculated by respondent positioning of each political party on the left–right scale, where 0 refers to extreme left and 10 to extreme right. Table 1 shows the mean and median on respondents’ left–right placement of parties in Belgium.

According to respondents’ views on party ideology, all the incumbent governing parties on the federal level are leaning toward the center to center-right, which allows us to incorporate all three dimensions of the economic voting in a single model. Both patrimonial voters and those who believe government should not reduce income inequality are expected to vote for a political party on the right. Furthermore, the 2019 elections had clear economic ideological division where the socialist, radical left, and green parties raised the fight against inequality as a salient issue, while the center or center-right focused on economic growth through lower taxation. Out of the seven political parties in our analysis of the Flanders region, Vlaams Belang is considered to be extreme right and does not have incumbency status. The overall impression, then, of the Flanders coalition parties is that of the

2. Voters were asked to fill in the paper questionnaire and mail it back or to fill out an online questionnaire.

Table 1. Ideological Position of Parties in Flanders and Wallonia Based on Respondents' Evaluation

Parties in Flanders	Mean	Median	Parties in Wallonia	Mean	Median
Open					
VLD	5.85	6	Ecolo	3.56	3
N-VA	7.70	8	cdH	5.12	5
Vlaams					
Belang	8.89	10	MR	7.33	8
CD&V	4.89	5	PP	6.45	8
PVDA	1.61	0	DéFI	5.64	5
Groen	2.73	2	PTB	1.67	1
sp.a	2.67	2	PS	2.69	2

Note. PTB, Parti du travail de Belgique (The Worker's Party of Belgium); sp.a, Socialistische Partij Anders (Socialist Party - Flanders).

center-right,³ with opposition on the center-left (with a bit among the radical parties both on the left and on the right). This classification in Flanders is ideal for testing multidimensional economic voters simultaneously, as all dimensions lead to the same essential binary differentiation. Regarding the regional elections in Flanders, the three incumbent parties on the federal level were also incumbents on the regional level, constituting stable regional governance throughout the whole five-year period.

Contrary to Flanders, in Wallonia there is variation in incumbency status between federal and regional incumbency and in the clarity of the ideological positioning. First, MR, a center-right party was incumbent at both the regional and federal levels. However, ideologically there are several other parties that could also be considered right or center-right parties, such as the People's Party (PP) and Démocrate Fédéraliste Indépendant (DéFI). Second, although at the federal level MR was the single party with incumbency status from Wallonia, holding also a prime minister position, at the regional level MR was in coalition with cdH, a center party in our sample (mean respondents' value on the ideology scale is 5.12, with a median of 5). The MR-cdH coalition at the regional level in Wallonia had an overall center/center-right

ideological leaning.⁴ However, the political situation during the regional governing term in Wallonia was somewhat convoluted, with a change in government occurring during the term. The winning party in the previous 2014 regional elections in Wallonia, the PS, resigned from the governing position following major political scandals. Nevertheless, by the time our survey was conducted, the MR-cdH coalition had been almost two years in power at the regional level and thus was considered as an incumbent coalition with center-right ideological positioning.

Main analysis

With our main analysis, first we focused on the entire dataset, pooling the two major regions, Flanders and Wallonia, in one sample to investigate the Belgian multidimensional economic voter (hypothesis 1). (See fig. 1, and the full results presented in app. 1, table 1a.) We find a clear pattern for the occurrence of the compleat economic voter in Belgium, where all three economic voting dimensions (valence, economic position, and high-risk patrimony) are positively associated with support for the incumbent parties. Those satisfied with the economy reported support for the incumbent parties in the federal elections. Valence is statistically significant, with a predicted value of 65% voting for the incumbent coalition government among those who reported the economy was doing very well ($\beta = .479$; $p < .001$; see fig. 3 in app. 3). Average marginal effects (AMEs) point to a 7.7% increase in support for incumbents for each unit increase in perceptions of economy.⁵ With regard to positional economics, we find 6.6% AME increase ($p < .001$) and predicted probability of 70% voting for incumbents when respondents are against government intervention to reduce inequalities. As expected, patrimony shows variation in importance, with high-risk assets having significant effect on vote for incumbents, while we do not find evidence of a similar effect on vote for incumbent party/coalition when it comes to low-risk patrimony. These effects for the multidimensional economic voter in Belgium remain significant despite inclusion of rather strong sets of control variables, including "satisfaction" with the federal government. Such findings underscore the inference that the compleat economic voter acts even in complex political systems such as in Belgium. The predicted probability of voting for an incumbent government based on each dimension of economic voting is presented in appendix 3, figure 3.

3. Note that CD&V in our sample of respondents has a mean value of 4.89 and median of 5, which infers center party. However, the coalition government in Flanders on both levels (i.e., federal and regional) was composed of right-wing Nationalists (the dominant party with 43 seats out of 124 in the regional parliament), the center Christian Democrats (27 seats), and the economically conservative Liberal Party (19 seats). As the Nationalists not only were the main coalition partner but also had the seat of the regional prime minister, they were effectively considered to be the senior coalition partner of this "center-right regional government."

4. For robustness, we also use an alternative dependent variable, coded as a vote for center-right/right in Wallonia. This includes the two additional right-wing parties, PP and DéFI, grouped with MR and cdH. The results, presented in app. 4 align fully with our theoretical claims below.

5. With around 44% difference in support for incumbents based on the full scale on economic evaluations, i.e., five-point scale (see app. 3, fig. 3).

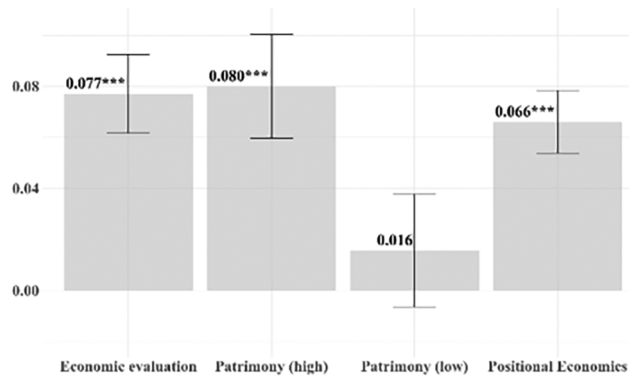


Figure 1. Multidimensional economic voting in Belgium. AMEs for multidimensional economic voter in Belgium with standard errors displayed. For full results of regression analysis, please see appendix 1, table 1a. * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$.

However, to fully investigate the variation of multidimensional economic voting by region, we turn to the regions as units of analysis. Because regions in Belgium have a high level of autonomy, with a regional authority index among the highest in Europe (Hooghe et al. 2016), aggregating the unit of analysis at the national level can lead to misleading findings. Therefore, we believe the more appropriate approach relies on investigation of Wallonia and Flanders separately, especially when it comes to hypothesis 2. The existence of two distinct party systems across the regions, one with Dutch-language voters and another with French-language voters, means that each region faces a different set of political choices. Further, historically the economic development of the two regions is diverse, likely leading to different channels of multidimensional economic voting. Thus, in the remaining part of the article, we shift the unit of analysis to the regional level, rather than federal, and focus on two sets of elections of first-order importance (i.e., federal and regional elections). In the following section, we first focus on the Flemish region before analyzing Walloon elections.

Flemish elections of 2019

The 2019 federal and regional elections in Flanders provide a unique setting for examining the multidimensional economic voter, given that the same three coalition parties were incumbents in both contests, federal and regional. Our findings from these elections yield two important insights. First, we find that in Flanders, multidimensional economic voting was an important factor for the 2019 elections. The economic position dimension emerged as a key predictor of vote choice for the center-right coalition parties in both the federal and regional elections. It surpassed valence as a determining factor, with AMEs indicating increased probability of voting for the incumbent coalition in regional elections by 8.5% for each

unit increase in positional economics. Similar effects are noted in the federal elections in Flanders with 7.7% AMEs (both significant at 0.1% level). In other words, those less keen on government interventions to reduce income disparities were more likely to report a vote for the center-right incumbent coalition governing parties. This underscores the significant impact of the positional economic dimension on the regional and federal elections in Flanders.

Similarly, we find positive significant effects of patrimony, specifically pertaining to high-risk asset ownership, and vote for incumbent parties in both federal and regional elections. That is, those who reported possessing more high-risk assets (stocks or bonds, a business, property, farm, or livestock ownership) were more likely to support the center-right incumbent parties. Notably, we found no evidence suggesting that ownership of low-risk assets had any effect on vote for incumbent coalition government in either the regional or federal elections.

Finally, we turn to the valence dimension, where we find that perceptions about the economy played an important and stable role in predicting support for incumbent parties in both federal and regional elections. These effects across the two elections were similar ($\beta = .286$ in federal; $\beta = .315$ in regional elections), with one unit increase in the belief that the economy had improved, resulting in an average increase of 4.9% in federal elections and 5.6% in regional elections in support of the incumbent coalition parties.

Two findings regarding the complete economic voter in Flanders bear special comment. First, we find large and substantive effects of positional economics as compared to valence (showing greater AMEs of about 3% compared to valence).⁶ This infers that center-right economic policies tend to have stronger support in Flanders, a region with historical liberal fiscal policies. Second, and related to positional economics, a fair share of the probability of voting for incumbent government can be attributed to high-risk patrimonial voters, which aligns with our expectations outlined in hypothesis 2.

In summary, the 2019 elections in Flanders were partly determined by the complete economic voter, acting in all their complexity. Second, we found that the 2019 regional and federal elections followed a very similar pattern. In both contests, all three factors (valence, high-risk patrimony, and positional economic) were important for the vote choice, but different dimensions may have exerted stronger effects. This latter finding contributes valuable insights to the literature on multilevel governance, suggesting that multidimensional economic voters also exist at the subnational level.

6. Note that valence and positional economics are on the same scale from 1 to 5.

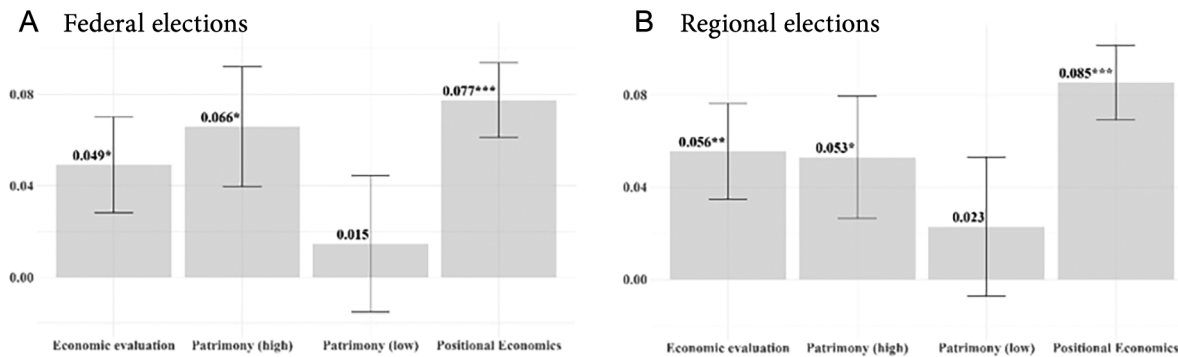


Figure 2. Multidimensional economic voting across type of elections in Flanders. AMEs for multidimensional economic voter in Flanders with standard errors displayed. For full results of regression analysis, please see appendix 1, table 1b. * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$.

2019 elections in Wallonia

When it comes to the election in the Walloon region, we find a different economic mechanism driving the vote choice across elections. First, voters in Wallonia were led by national economic perceptions (i.e., valence) more than by any other dimensions of the economic vote. That is, valence was the main economic driver in the federal and regional elections. Furthermore, it was the only dimension that had a significant impact on vote for incumbent governments in the federal elections. Although valence was an important factor in the regional elections as well, the effect size is a little bit lower (with AMEs suggesting a 6.3% increase in support for incumbents by each value of valence) as compared to the federal elections (7.1%). Second, positional economics played a significant role in the Wallonia regional elections, but its impact appears to be somewhat tempered. This lower effect of positional economic dimension in Wallonia can be attributed, in part, to the presence of a center-right regional coalition in a region that historically leans toward leftist economic ideologies. Our findings suggest that, on average, positional economics leads to about a 4.2% increase in support for an incumbent government coalition in the regional elections in Wallonia. Interestingly and in line with hypothesis 2b, our analysis finds no evidence of patrimonial voting in Wallonia, as with both high-risk asset and low-risk asset ownership, we find no effect on vote for incumbent governing parties. These results point to two main conclusions, which we discuss below.

First, the elections in Wallonia and Flanders appear to be driven by different types of economic dimensions. While Flanders demonstrates the full strength of multidimensional economic voting, this is more limited in Wallonia. In Wallonia, elections were predominantly driven by valence considerations. However, the compleat economic vote revealed greater complexity in the Walloon regional contest compared to the federal, where positional economics also mattered. This finding in Wallonia is consistent with our hypothesis 2b. Second,

focusing only on the nation level as unit of analysis imposes limitations on understanding the heterogeneous effects of multidimensional economic voting across regional settings, since they can be a product of different historical and economic developments, as specifically evident in Belgium.

ALTERNATIVE MODELING TECHNIQUES AND DATA EXTENSIONS

To test the robustness of our findings, we implement different modeling techniques to replicate our findings. First, we replicate our analysis using linear probability models (LPMs) with White-corrected standard errors for heteroscedasticity (see app. 2, tables 2a–2c). The results confirm the findings in figure 1 (i.e., all three dimensions of economic voting are significant predictors of vote for incumbent parties in Belgium [hypothesis 1]). Valence matters, with one unit increase on perceptions about the economy increasing the chances of voting for incumbents by 8.2% in federal elections. Similarly, having more high-risk assets is positively associated with voting for center-right incumbent coalition, as is the economic position that governments should not intervene to reduce inequality in society. The LPMs regarding hypothesis 2, where the unit of analysis is on a regional level, also confirm the results in figures 2 and 3. The only difference with LPMs is in Wallonia for the federal elections, where we find that positional economics is a predictor of vote for incumbent parties.

Second, restricting our models to the same sample size, using only those who have responded to all questions yields almost identical results to those presented in the article (see app. 3, tables 3a and 3b). This is to be expected as the sample size variation is very minimal, not more than 1% of the total sample size.⁷

7. For AME estimates by item, see app. 7.

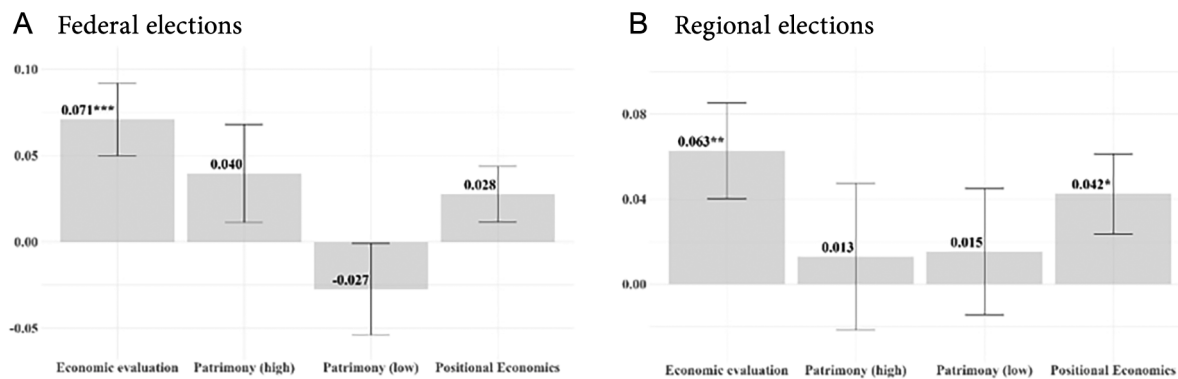


Figure 3. Multidimensional economic voting across type of elections in Wallonia. AMEs for multidimensional economic voter in Wallonia with standard errors displayed. For full results of regression analysis, please see appendix 1, table 1c. * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$.

Third, given the presence of two additional right-wing parties in Wallonia, we conducted a robustness test where vote choice in the Walloon regional elections was ideologically classified as a vote for center-right/right parties. This classification includes PP and DéFI alongside the incumbent parties MR and cdH. The results of this ideological classification confirm our initial findings (see app. 4 for further details).

We also tested our analysis via an out-of-sample test of hypotheses. We used similar cases matched to Wallonia and Flanders. Specifically, we used the 2012 French presidential elections as a similar case matched to Wallonia, and the 2013 parliamentary elections in Germany and Austria as cases matched to Flanders (see app. 5 for details). These out-of-sample tests also confirmed our hypothesis that different economic developments lead to different sets of multidimensional economic voters across Europe, extending the scope of our findings.

Finally, we test our claim that a different economic development has led to variation in multidimensional economic voters across Wallonia and Flanders. To do this, we regressed our full models from tables 1b and 1c on an economic item that measures respondents' views on government spending for companies and industry. The results, presented in appendix 6, align with our theoretical expectations. Notably, government spending for companies and industry is not favored among high-risk patrimonial owners in Flanders.

SUMMARY AND DISCUSSION

The classical theory of economic voting starts from the assumption that national economic conditions clearly determine electoral support for incumbent political parties. However, in recent years, it has been argued that economic voting should not be reduced to a single dimension. We tested the multidimensionality of the concept, using recent election survey results from Belgium. A special feature of the Belgian political

system is that elections are held simultaneously, for the federal and regional level. For both elections, we can indeed observe that voters are motivated by various economic considerations in their decision to support incumbent political parties. Not only the perception of the national economy but also their views on economic policy and their patrimonial ownership come into play in the vote decision. To a large extent, these different economic considerations appear to be more important than ideological determinants of the vote choice. Thus, our first contribution to the literature consists in showing that even in Belgium, where the complicated structure of federalism makes the clarity of responsibility a difficult goal to achieve, the complete economic voter manages to emerge as a powerful force at the ballot box. However, the condition of the multidimensional economic voter is that, at least in a broader sense, incumbent parties should be ideologically allied (i.e., a basic level of ideological clarity is necessary for such complete economic voting).

Our second contribution suggests that economic development is crucial for shaping the characteristics of economic voters. By examining differences in regional economic development within Belgium, we find that these historical and economic trajectories may shape the economic vote in different ways. For example, in Wallonia, a region historically associated with strongholds of the PS, with a higher level of labor protectionism, the electoral dynamics provide stronger incentives for valence voters. This encourages a greater emphasis on state regulations to mitigate income inequalities. In such an environment, we observe limited patrimonial voting, particularly among those with high-risk asset ownership. In contrast, the complete economic voter in Flanders seems to be driven by all aspects of multidimensional economic voting. Here, there is a specific emphasis on reduced state involvement in economic policies, higher market-regulated business that leads to an increase in high-risk patrimonial voting. Overall, our

study suggests that multidimensional economic voting is an important, sometimes subtle, factor in understanding regional and national elections in the context of multilevel governance.

Despite these contributions, we acknowledge several limitations to our study. First, the change in government on regional level in Wallonia provides a somewhat lower level of clarity of responsibility among voters (even though the two governing parties were in power for the two years leading up to the regional elections). Second, the regional government in Wallonia was composed of two ideologically distinct governments. The second coalition in Wallonia (MR and cdH) was considered distinctly center-right, as compared to the first two years led by a distinctly left-wing coalition between PS and cdH. The evidence of this lies in respondents' perceptions of cdH as center even leading to the center-right party in our survey (respondents classify cdH with average score of 5.12 on the ideological scale). Additionally, robustness analysis imposing center to center-right ideological classification of our dependent variable in Wallonia confirmed our theoretical claims. Finally, the incumbency status in Flanders leading up to the elections made the elections more complex (with the largest party N-VA leaving the governing coalition five months before the elections). Yet, the central role of N-VA during the term, and the stability as governing party in the regional elections, allows N-VA to be truly considered incumbent in the 2019 elections. This would suggest that voters indeed consider the entire legislature and not just the events in the months before the elections. This possibility, along with others alluded to, provide fodder for examination at the next set of Belgian elections. Considering the complex case of Belgium, the 2019 elections manifested a notable clarity of ideological incumbency, offering a unique window of opportunity to explore the comprehensive nature of the multidimensional economic voter, a rarity within the Belgian federal system.

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